ELIMINATION PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; remember that it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular elimination play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

There are four or five stages shown for each Deal.

You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

ELIMINATION PLAYS SUMMARY

There are a lot of card combinations in Bridge in which you will be better off if the opponents make the first play in a suit than you would be if you must play it first. Here are three examples.

♦ K 10 3	♦ J 7 3	♦ K 10 3
♦ A J 7	♦ Q 5 2	♦ A 9 7

The first is the frequently occurring two-way finesse. If you play this yourself you have to guess which defender holds the Queen. If the defenders start the suit you automatically win all three tricks.

In the second example you'd like to win one trick, and it will be hard to do if you must start the suit. Perhaps one defender holds both the high honors and you can guess which one and lead through him. Or perhaps someone has a doubleton honor that you can deduce. But if the defenders break the suit you just play second-hand-low and can't miss winning one trick.

With the third example you have almost no chance of three tricks if you start. If they start the suit you play second-hand-low and the next defender must play an honor. You win and then finesse the other defender for the other honor, winning all three tricks when their two honors are divided.

These are only three of many combinations that will benefit you if you can force the defenders to start the suit.
And that is what Elimination plays do; force the defenders to play a particular suit for you.

It works like this. You **strip** the defenders of all their "safe" exit suits, then you **throw-in** one of the defenders. If he has no safe exit, he will have to play a suit that will benefit you, perhaps one of the combinations above.

You will find that most elimination plays occur in suit contracts. This is because you can often pull all the defender's trumps while retaining at least one in both your hand and dummy. Then when the throw-in occurs the defense cannot play a suit of which you and dummy are both void because of the threat of a ruff and sluff.

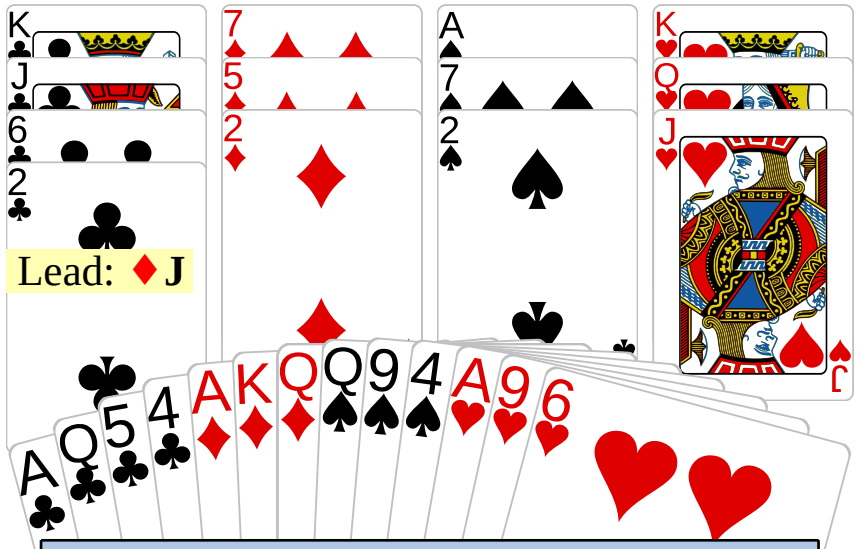
25 examples are probably worth more than 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



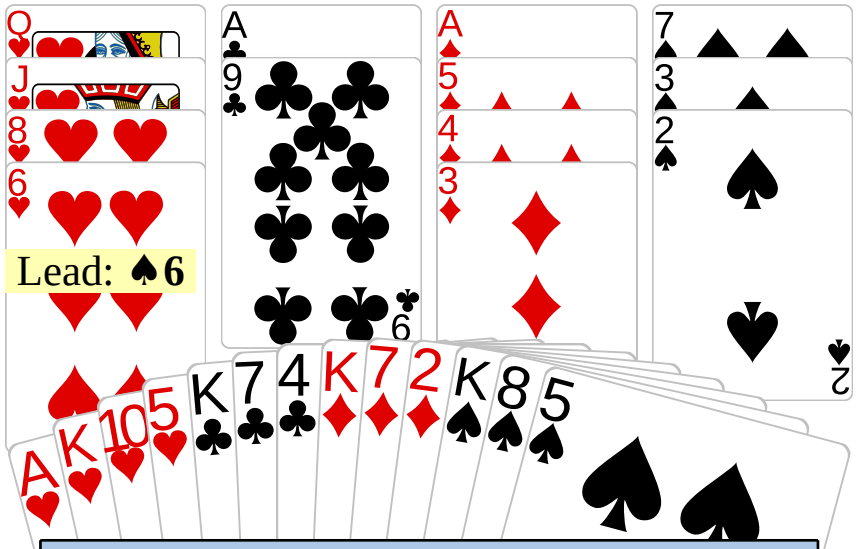
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **6NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



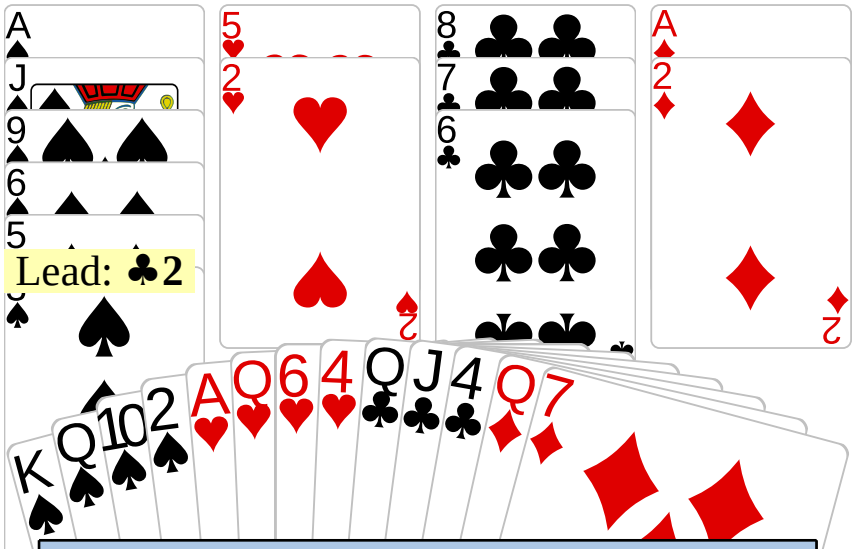
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



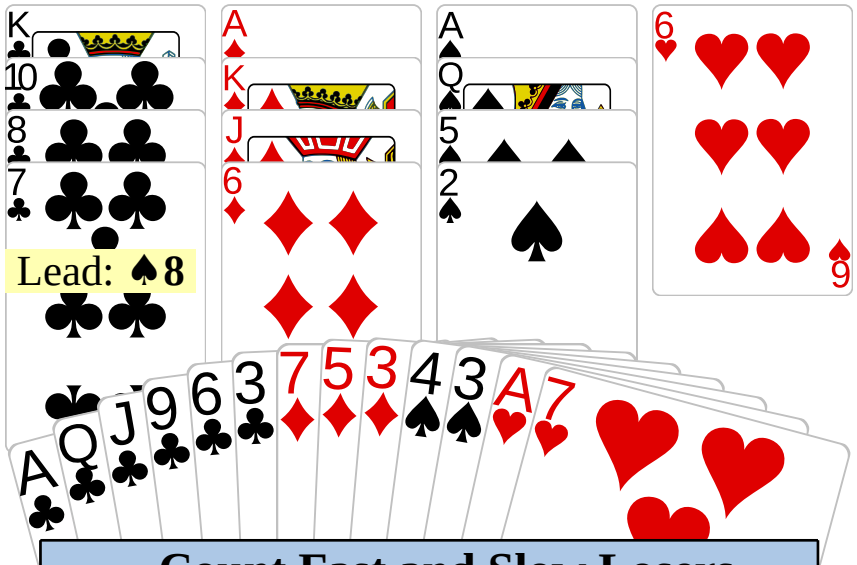
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **6♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total

Decide How to Reduce Losers			
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠5

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦J

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠6

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣2

Board: 5
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠8

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A J ♥ A Q 10 9 4 3 ♦ J ♣ A J 9 4	
♠ K 9 4 3 ♥ 8 5 ♦ 10 8 5 3 2 ♣ 7 6		♠ Q 10 8 5 2 ♥ 6 ♦ Q 9 7 ♣ K Q 5 2
	♠ 7 6 ♥ K J 7 2 ♦ A K 6 4 ♣ 10 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

6♥ by North
Lead: ♠5

After hearing a limit raise, North's leap to 6♥ is, well, bold let's say. North plays 6♥. East leads the ♠5, dummy plays the ♠6 and West the ♠K.

Dummy wins the ♦K.

Dummy leads the ♦A and West follows.

Very bold in fact. The opening lead has exposed a ♠ loser in addition to your two ♣ losers. On the plus side dummy has an extra ♦ trick. You are going to have to try to throw East in with the ♣ suit, but you will have to be very careful with dummy's entries.

Win the ♠A, play the ♦J to dummy's ♦K and discard the ♠J on dummy's ♦A.

You are in dummy, so ruff the ♠7 with a high trump. Next play the ♥9 to dummy's ♥J. Both defenders follow, whew!

Back in dummy, ruff a ♦ with the ♥Q, then lead the ♥10 to dummy's ♥K, pulling the last trump as you enter dummy.

It would be great if you could ruff dummy's last ♦, then get back to dummy with a trump so you could lead a ♣ from dummy and finesse. But check your trumps. If you do that you will have no more trumps in your hand and East won't be endplayed because you have no ruff-sluff. The only thing you can do is to go ahead and play ♣s now, finessing into East and HOPING he has no more ♦s!

You were lucky, East had only three ♦s so your partial elimination worked.

But if it had turned out that East DID have another ♦, and led it, all would not be lost. You would ruff in your hand, play a trump to dummy, then take a second ♣ finesse. If it turned out the ♣K and ♣Q were in different hands you would make the slam.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ —
♥ 8 7 4 3 2
♦ 9 6 4 3
♣ 10 9 8 7

♠ A 7 2
♥ K Q J
♦ 7 5 2
♣ K J 6 2



♠ Q 9 4
♥ A 9 6
♦ A K Q
♣ A Q 5 4

♠ K J 10 8 6 5 3
♥ 10 5
♦ J 10 8
♣ 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	3♠
6NT			
All Pass			

6NT by East
Lead: ♦J

Some bidding, huh? Well, what would you have bid in the West seat? East plays 6NT. South leads the ♦J.

Mirror distributions! So you can only make ten tricks in ♥s, ♦s and ♣s.

That means you will have to make two ♠ tricks. And since the odds are 5000 to 1 that South has the ♠K, leading toward your ♠Q is NOT your play.

Win the ♦ and play 4 rounds of ♣s. South follows to the first, then discards 3 ♠s.

Next play 3 ♥ winners. South follows twice, then discards a ♠.

Now play your 2 ♦ winners. North and South both follow.

Keeping your fingers crossed that South must win the next trick,

South puts on the ♠10.

North (thankfully) discards a ♥.

South has been thrown in and he has nothing left but the ♠ K J. Whichever one he plays you will take the last two tricks.

South no doubt thought his 3♠ bid was a good idea.

In fact, it just kept you from making a losing play, (leading toward the ♠Q), and allowed you to find the end-play to make the slam.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 3 2 ♥ Q J 8 6 ♦ A 5 4 3 ♣ A 9	
♠ 6 ♥ 9 4 3 ♦ J 10 9 6 ♣ Q 10 8 3 2	N W E S	♠ A Q J 10 9 4 ♥ 7 2 ♦ Q 8 ♣ J 6 5
	♠ K 8 5 ♥ A K 10 5 ♦ K 7 2 ♣ K 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	2♠	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♠6

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♠6, taken by East with the ♠A. East returns the ♠Q, you play the ♠K and West ruffs. West next leads the ♦J.

After that unfortunate start you seem to be in a bit of trouble. Two tricks are already in the defender's pockets and you still have a ♠ loser and a ♦ loser. So you win with your ♦K and play two rounds of trumps.

The good news is that West started with three trumps, and since he already used one it only takes two pulls to pick up the remaining trumps.

Eliminate ♣s by playing ♣A, ♣K, and ruffing a ♣. Both defenders follow to all three ♣s.

So far East has followed suit to every trick, meaning he has not discarded a single ♠. Since you know he started with 6 ♠s, his final 5 cards consist of 4 ♠s and one other. You play to the ♦A and East follows suit again.

Dummy's ♠7: East wins, but he has nothing left but ♠s. When he plays another ♠ you discard your ♦ loser and ruff in dummy.

This is called a Partial Elimination because all of the ♦s were not eliminated.

However, the key is that you could tell they were eliminated from the East hand, and East was going to be the throw-in target because of his long ♠s.

In many hands an opponent who opens with a preemptive bid gives you the information you need to plan and execute the throw-in.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 7 ♥ K 9 7 3 ♦ K 9 6 3 ♣ K 10 5 2	
♠ K Q 10 2 ♥ A Q 6 4 ♦ Q 7 ♣ Q J 4	N W E S	♠ A J 9 6 5 3 ♥ 5 2 ♦ A 2 ♣ 8 7 6
	♠ 8 4 ♥ J 10 8 ♦ J 10 8 5 4 ♣ A 9 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♥	Pass
2♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♣2

East first transfers you to ♠s, then closes the auction with 4♠.

West is to play 4♠. North leads the ♣2. South takes the ♣A and returns the ♣9 to North's ♣K. North plays another ♣ to your ♣Q.

With two tricks lost already you have a sure ♦ loser (unless the defenders goof) and a ♥ loser that might be taken care of if South holds the ♥K. But what if North holds the ♥K? Maybe an elimination play.

First pull trumps - they split 2-1.

Next eliminate ♦s by playing ♦A then another ♦. This does the elimination and throw-in at the same time.

If the defender who won the ♦K plays a ♦ or a ♣ you will ruff in your hand and discard dummy's ♥ loser. So that defender is going to have to lead a ♥.

If it is North who won the ♦K you are home free. His ♥ play will give you two ♥ tricks.

If it is South who won the ♦K you still have a chance. He will lead a ♥ and you will finesse the ♥Q.

In other words, played this way you make the contract whenever North holds the ♦K **OR** South holds the ♥K.

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With the cards as shown the elimination play works.

But if the ♦K is with South and the ♥K with North it wouldn't.

Of course it is POSSIBLE that if you played a low ♦ from dummy some Easts would duck and let you win a trick with your ♦Q.

This trickery would fail if North held the ♦K, or if South held it and went up right away.

Board 5
West Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 4 3 ♥ A 7 ♦ 7 5 3 ♣ A Q J 9 6 3	
♠ K J 10 9 7 6 ♥ K 10 3 ♦ Q 8 2 ♣ 4	N W E S	♠ 8 ♥ Q J 9 8 5 4 2 ♦ 10 9 4 ♣ 5 2
	♠ A Q 5 2 ♥ 6 ♦ A K J 6 ♣ K 10 8 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2♠	3♣	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	6♣
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♣ by North
Lead: ♠8

dummy's ♠Q.

A fairly complex elimination play to finish off the set.

I hope you enjoyed them.

North plays 6♣. East leads the ♠8.

You have one ♠ loser and one ♦ loser. A successful finesse will take care of either one of them. Chance of the ♠ finesse working? Zero. Chance of the ♦ finesse working? Maybe 50%. Chance of an elimination play? Priceless.

Win the ♠A and pull trumps with the ♣A and ♣Q. They split 2-1.

Play the ♦A, just in case there is a singleton ♦Q somewhere. There isn't. Then eliminate ♥s by playing ♥A and ruff a ♥.

A low ♠ from both hands. East doesn't follow suit as West wins with a small card.

West is end-played. He has no ♣s. If he plays a ♦ it will be into dummy's ♦ K J. If he plays a ♥ you will discard a ♦ from your hand and ruff in dummy. If he plays the ♠K you will ruff, and dummy's ♠Q will be promoted. If he plays a small ♠ you will let it ride to